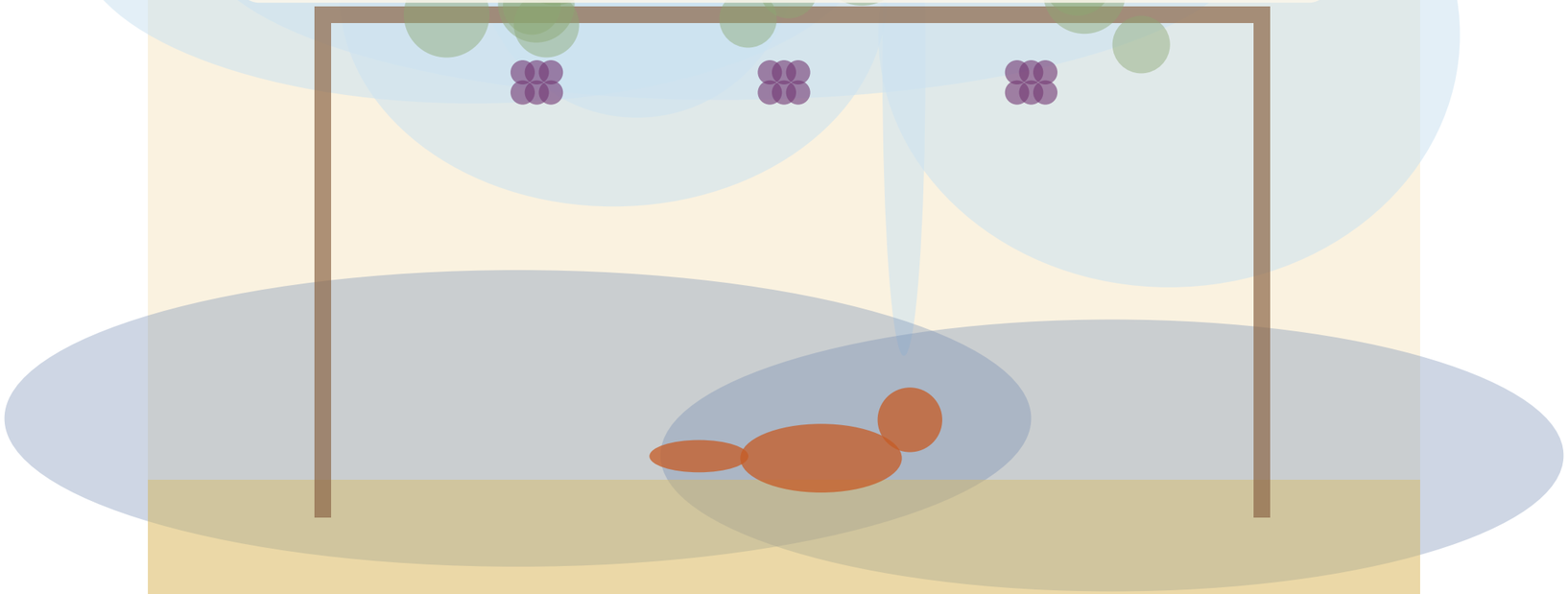
ART PLACEHOLDER

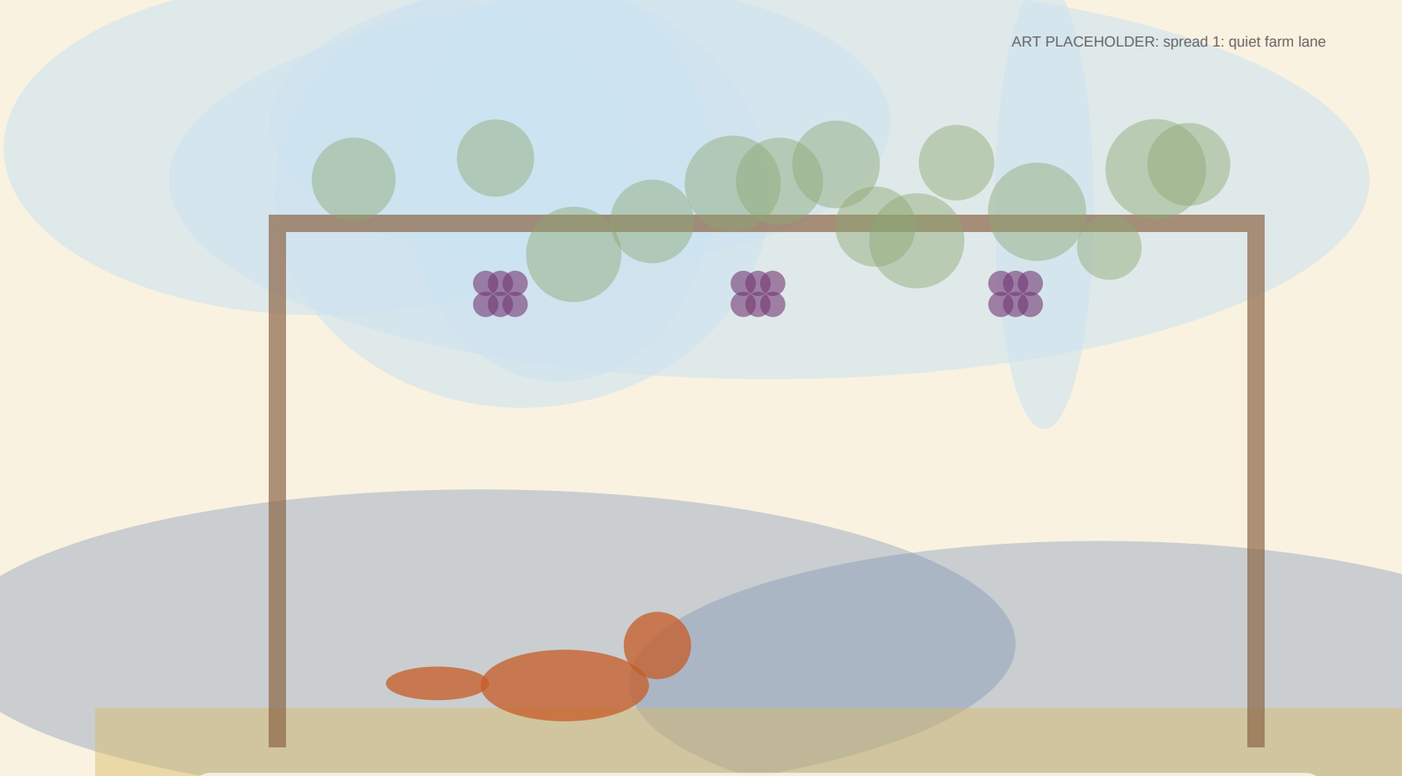
Fern and the High Grapes



A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes

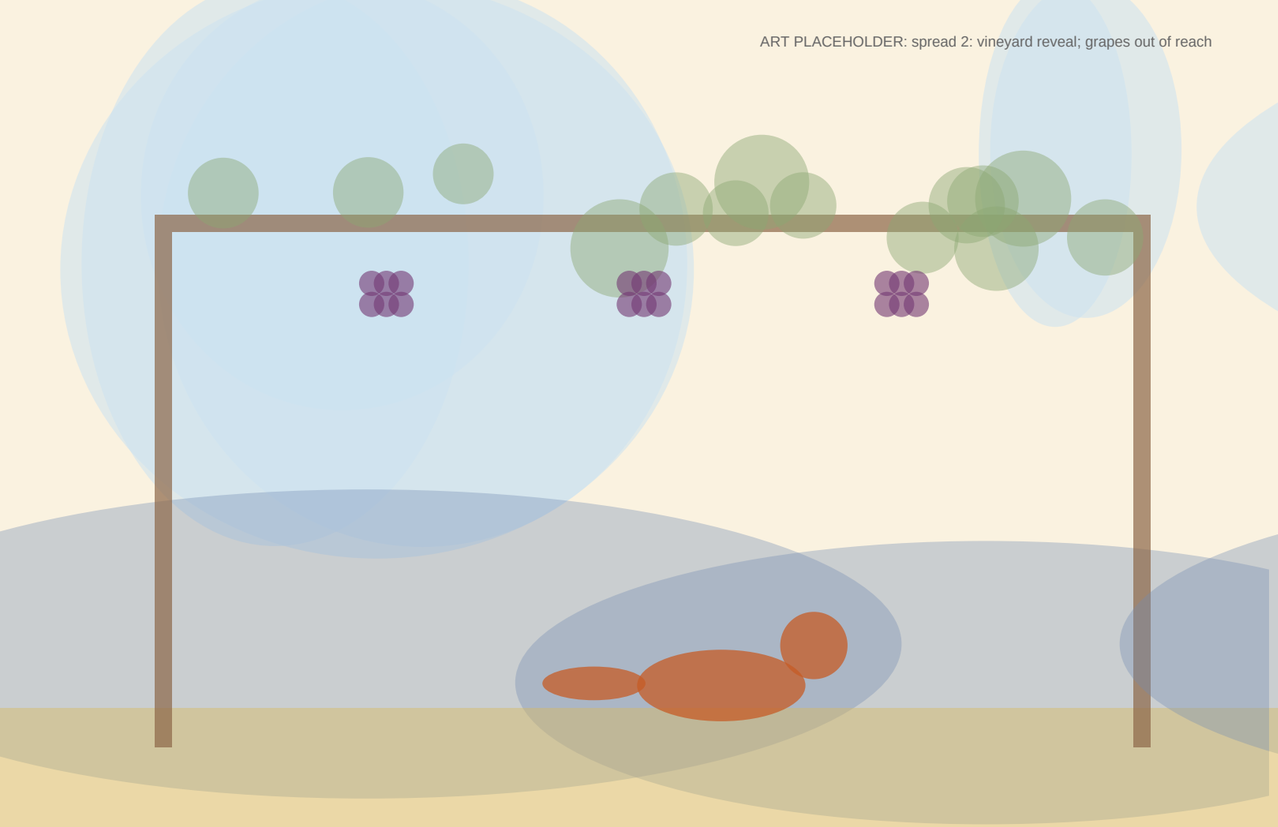
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ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 1: quiet farm lane



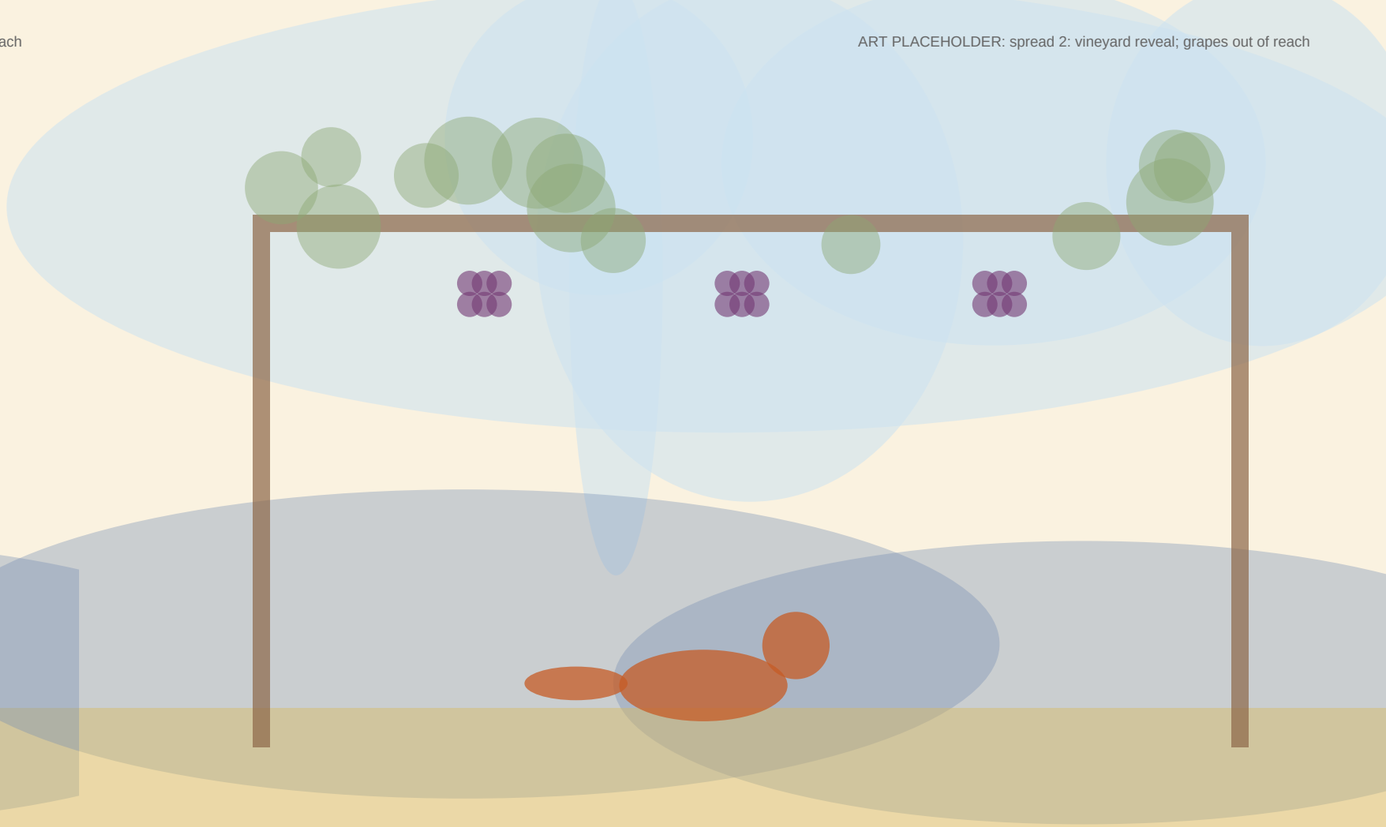
A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 2: vineyard reveal; grapes out of reach



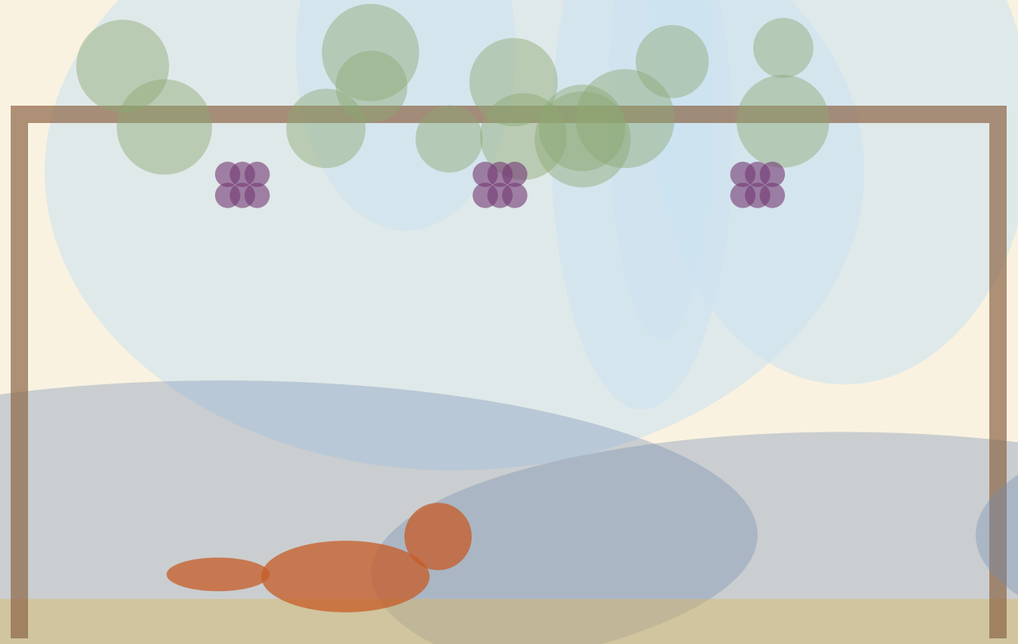
Along a farm lane, Fern the fox sniffed the warm summer air.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 2: vineyard reveal; grapes out of reach



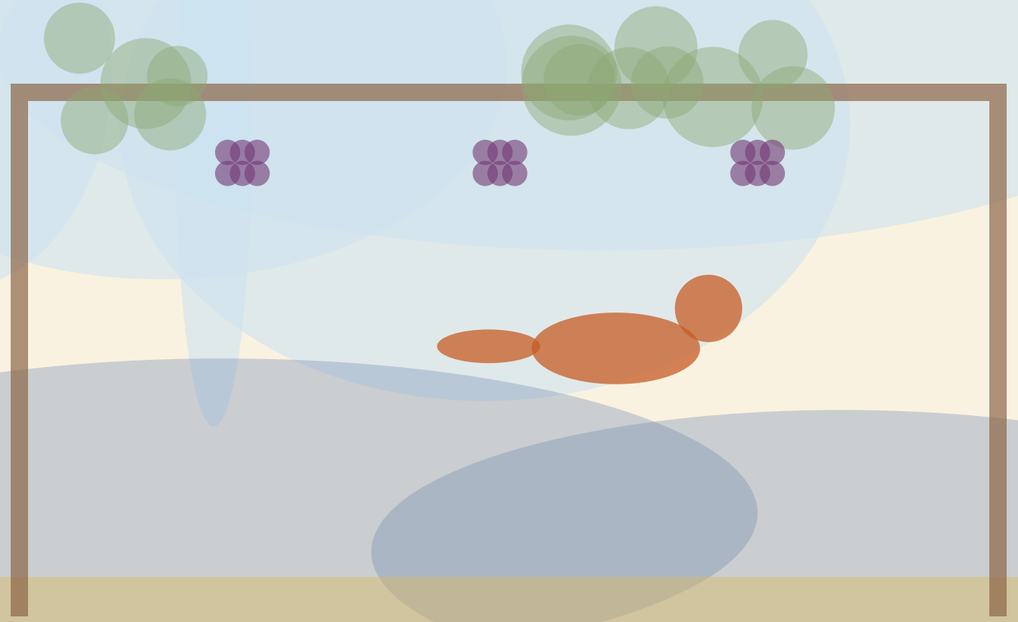
Sweet grapes hung from a vine overhead. Fern’s tummy rumbled.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 3: robin; first jump



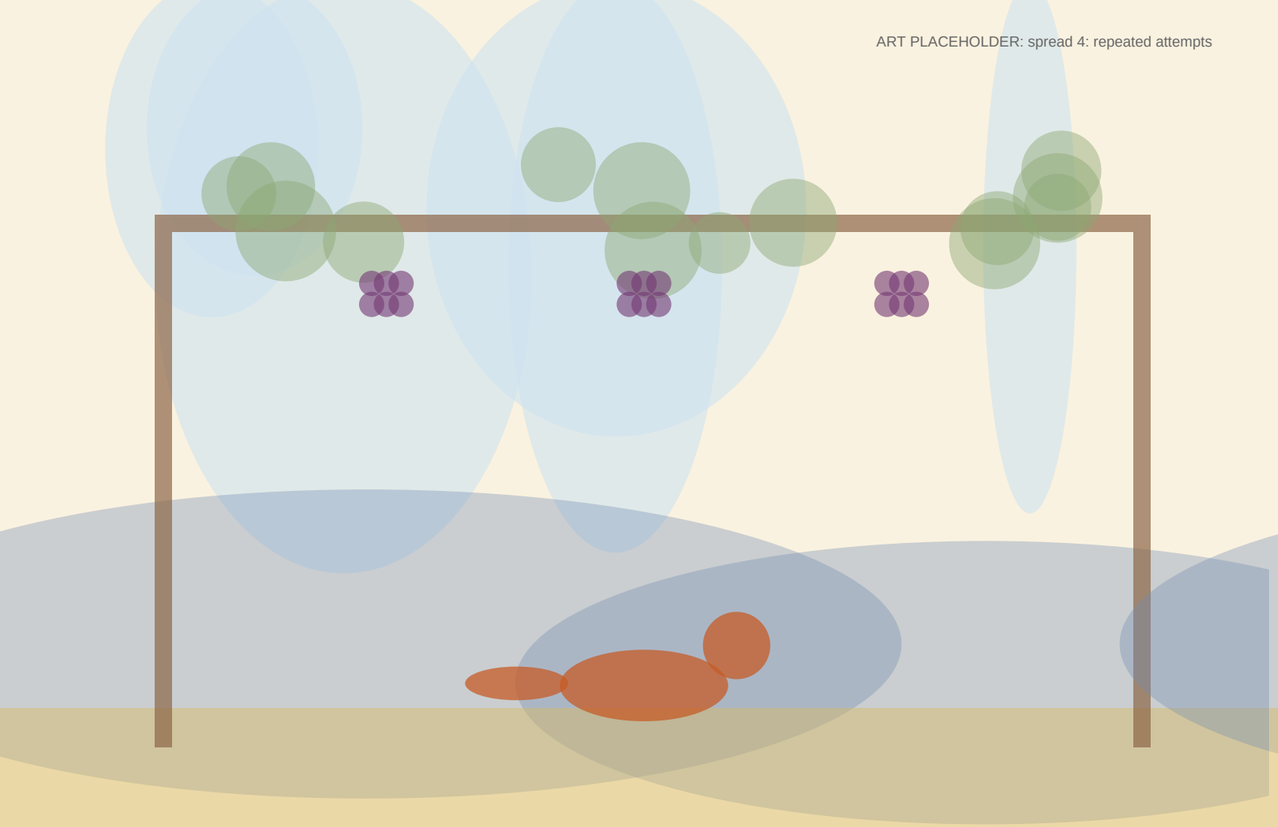
A robin perched beside a bunch. Fern wished she could reach it, too.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 3: robin; first jump



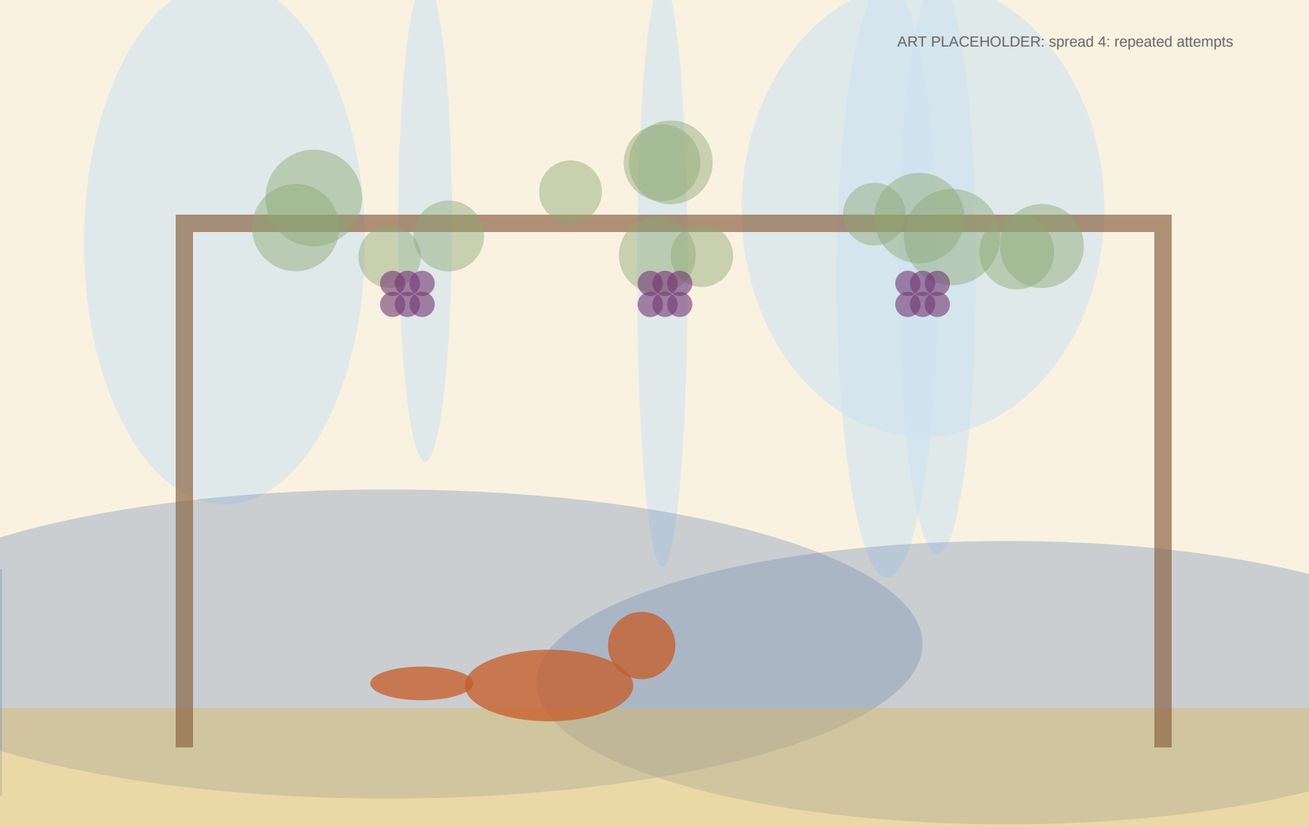
She crouched low, swished her tail, and sprang. Almost!

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 4: repeated attempts



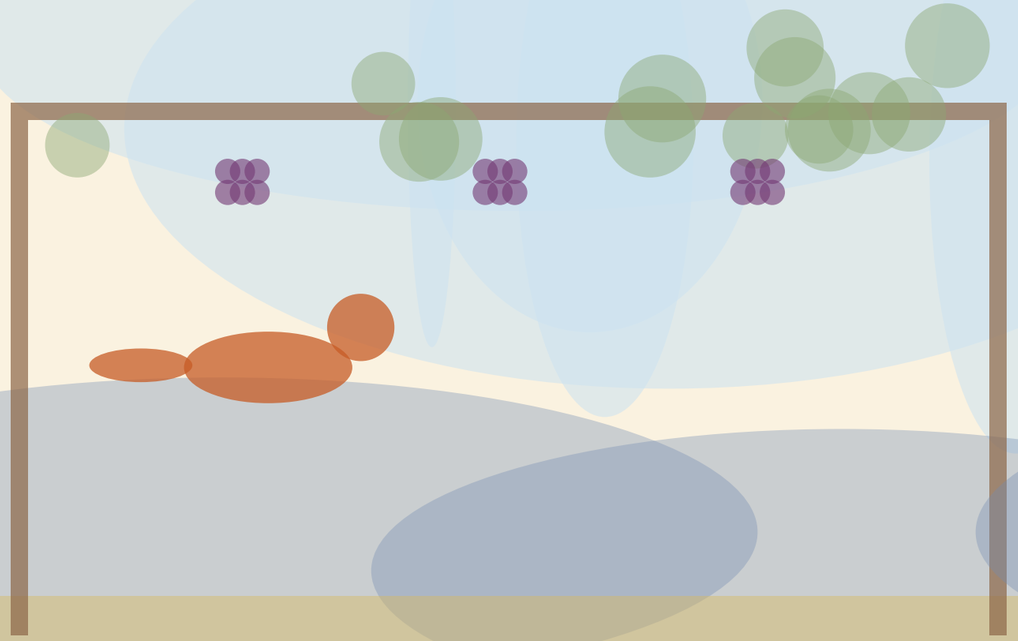
She tried from the left. She tried from the right.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 4: repeated attempts



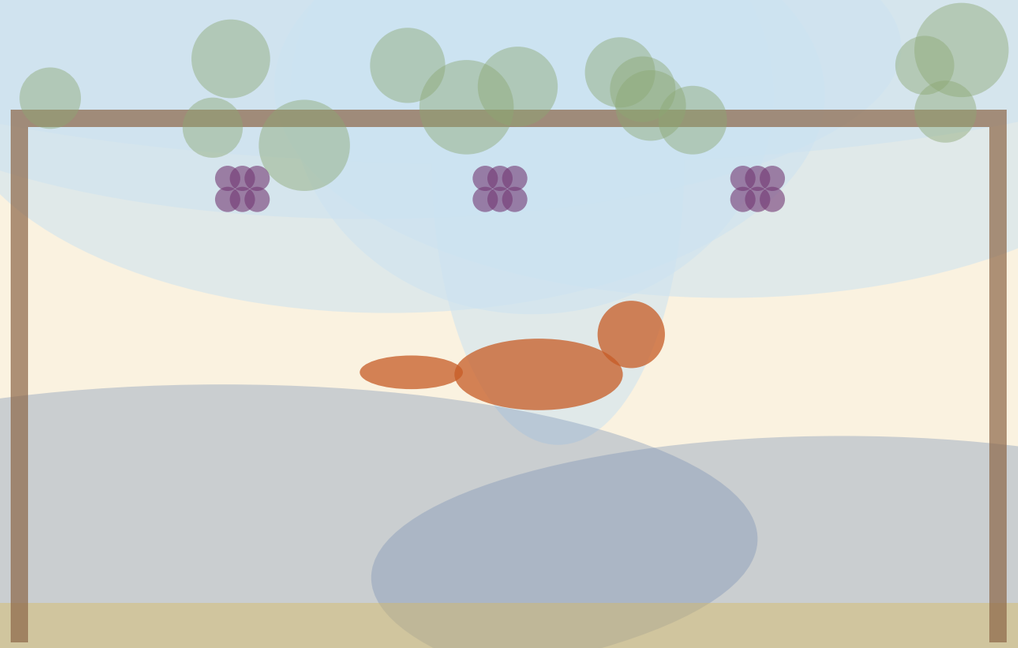
Up went her paws. Down came her paws. The grapes stayed high.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 5: big jump; soft landing



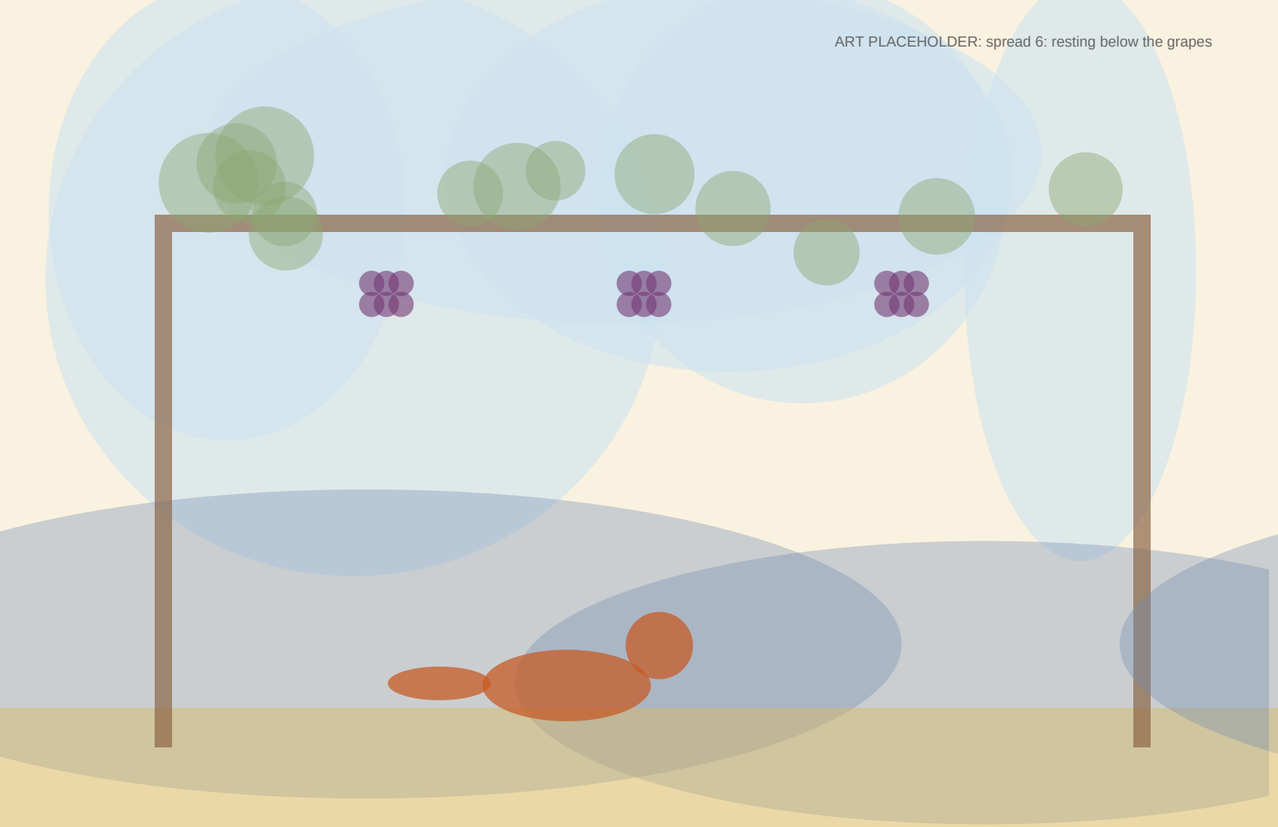
Fern backed up for one enormous jump.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 5: big jump; soft landing



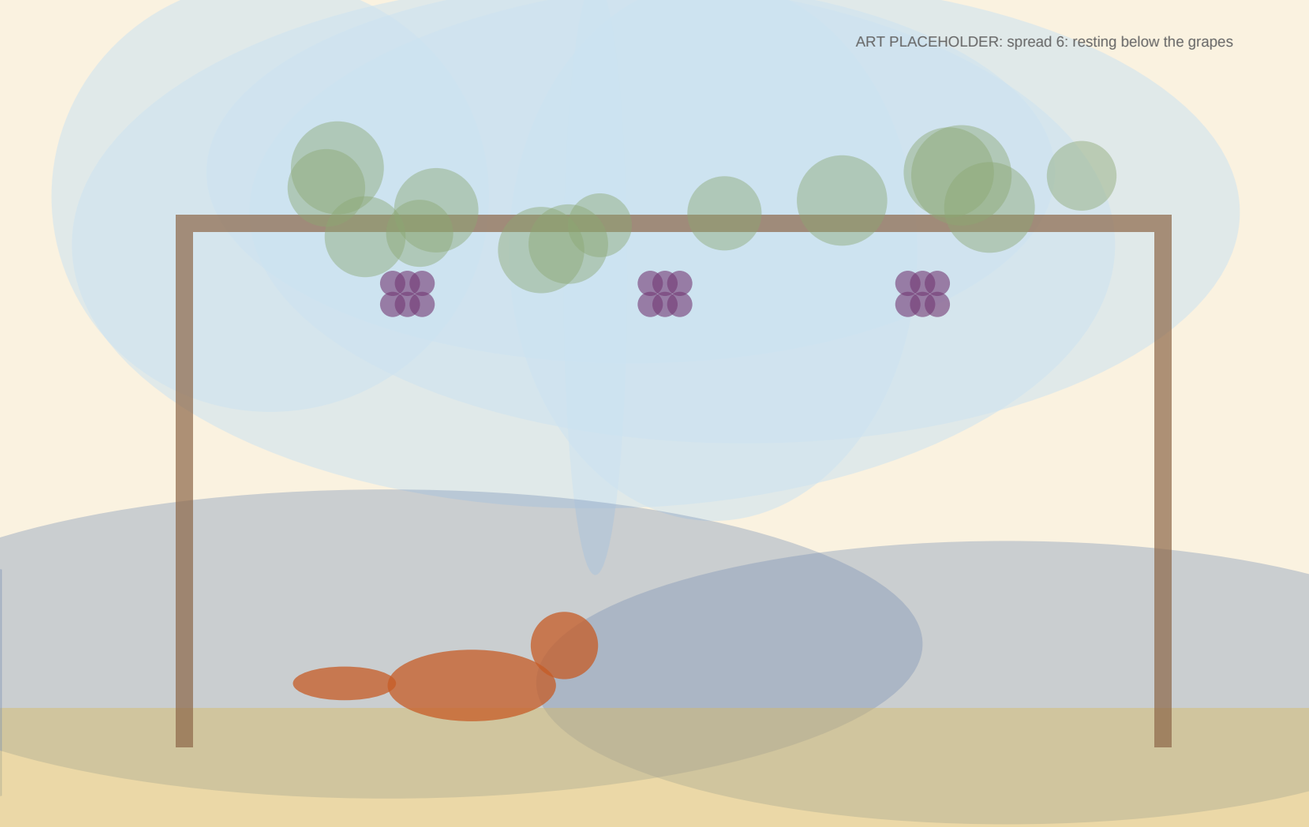
Whoosh! Her nose brushed a leaf. Plop! She landed in the grass.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 6: resting below the grapes



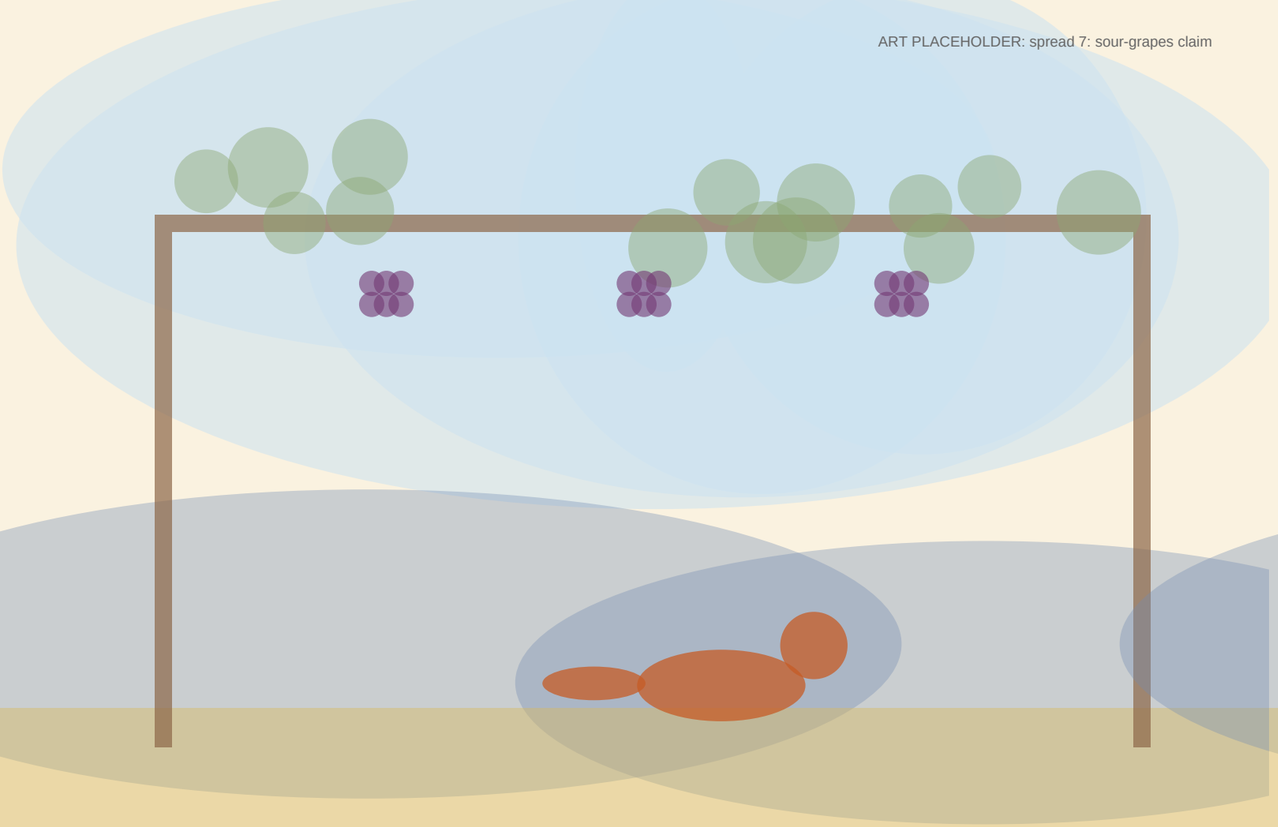
Fern sat down, puffing. She was tired, hungry, and disappointed.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 6: resting below the grapes



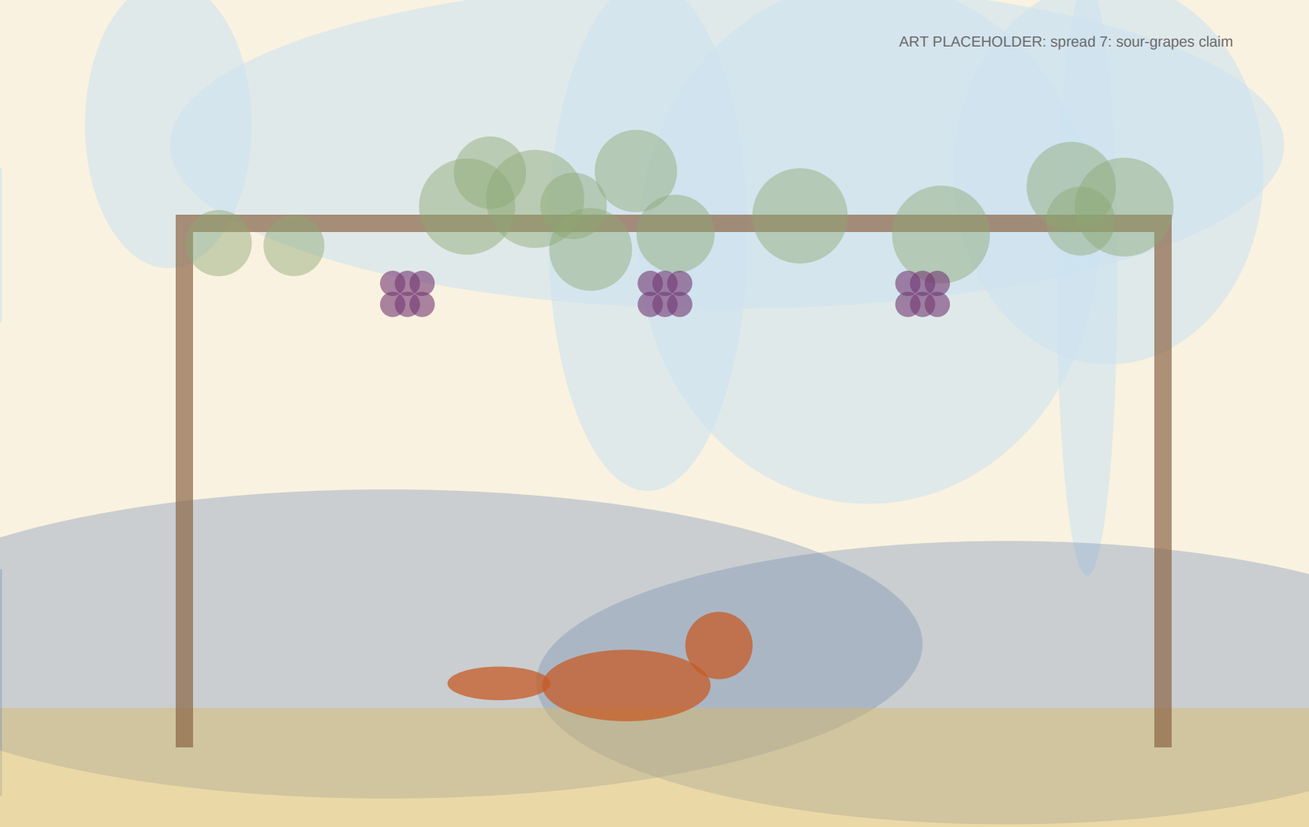
Above her, the grapes glowed purple in the sun.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 7: sour-grapes claim



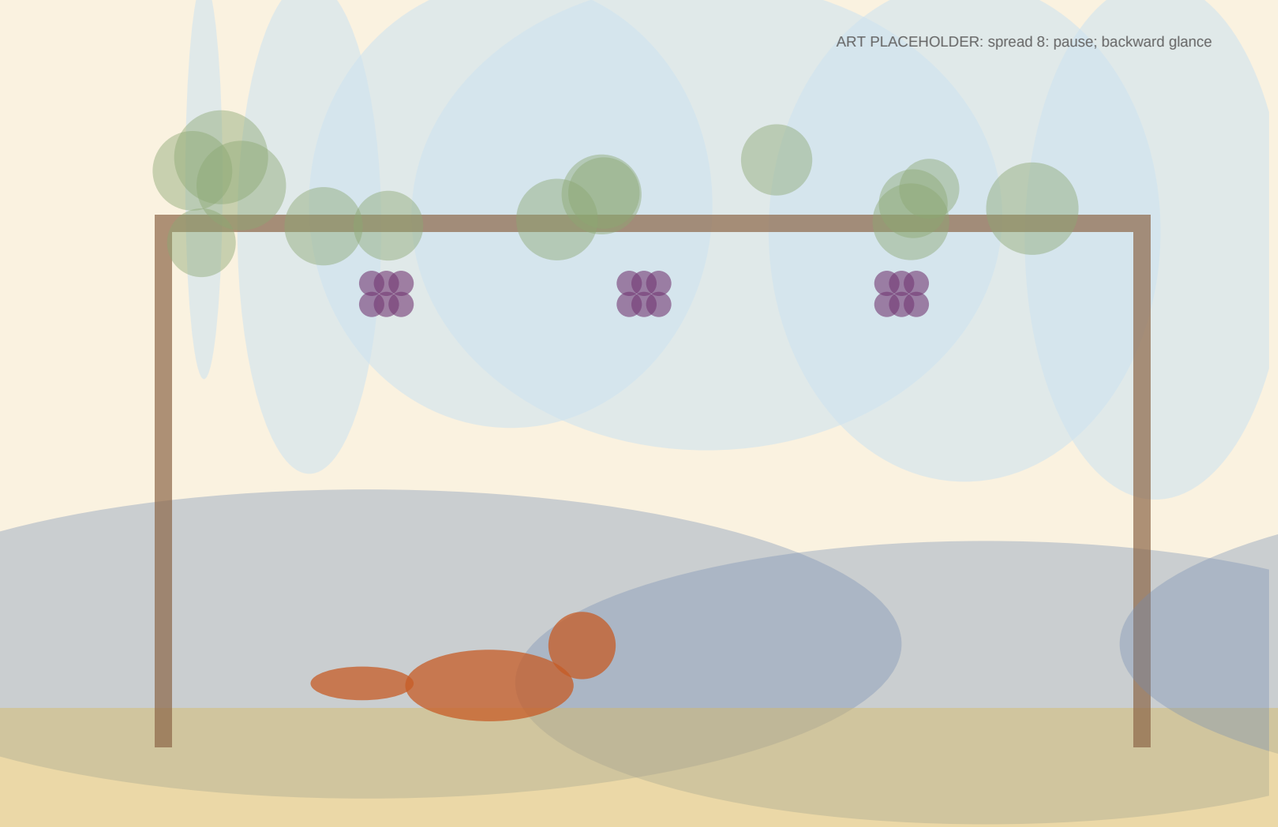
“They must be sour,” she grumbled. “I wouldn’t want them anyway.”

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 7: sour-grapes claim



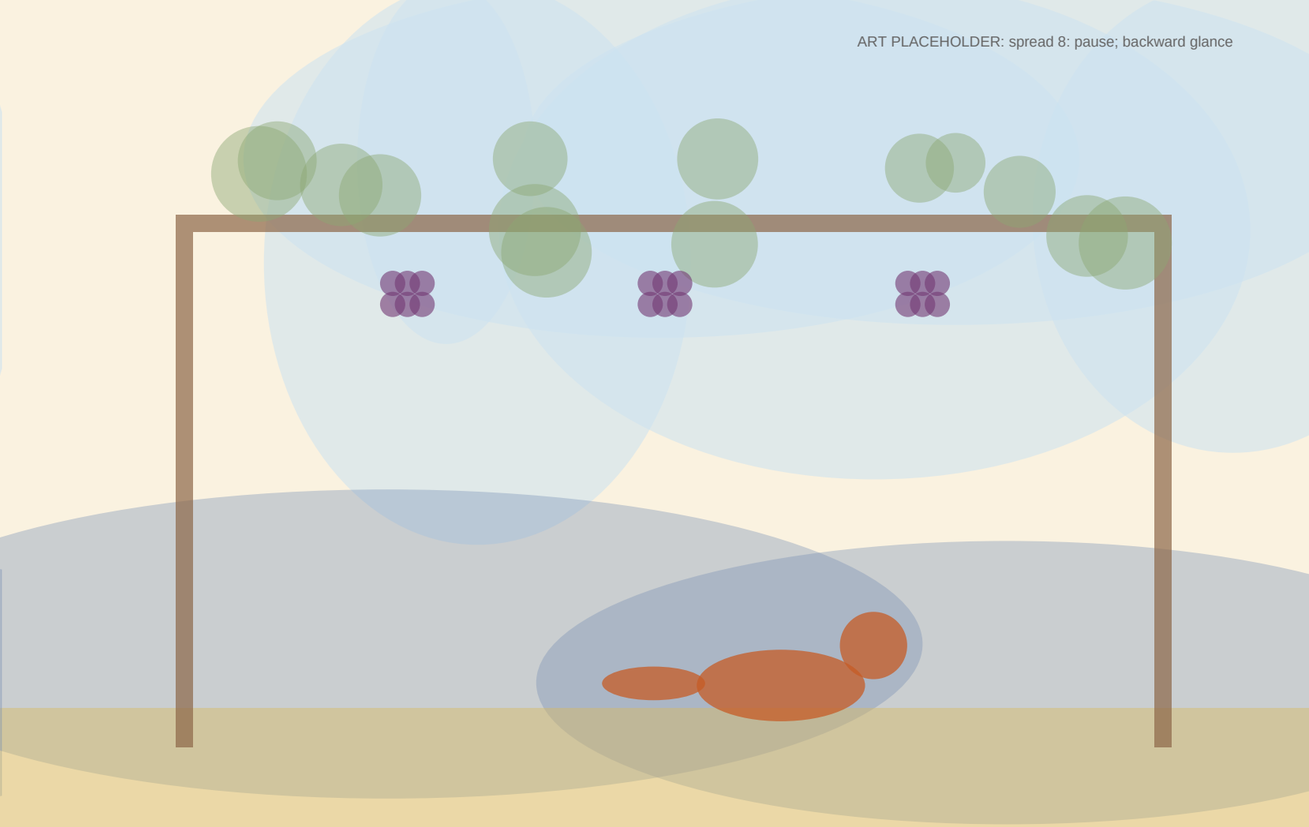
She turned away with her nose in the air.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 8: pause; backward glance



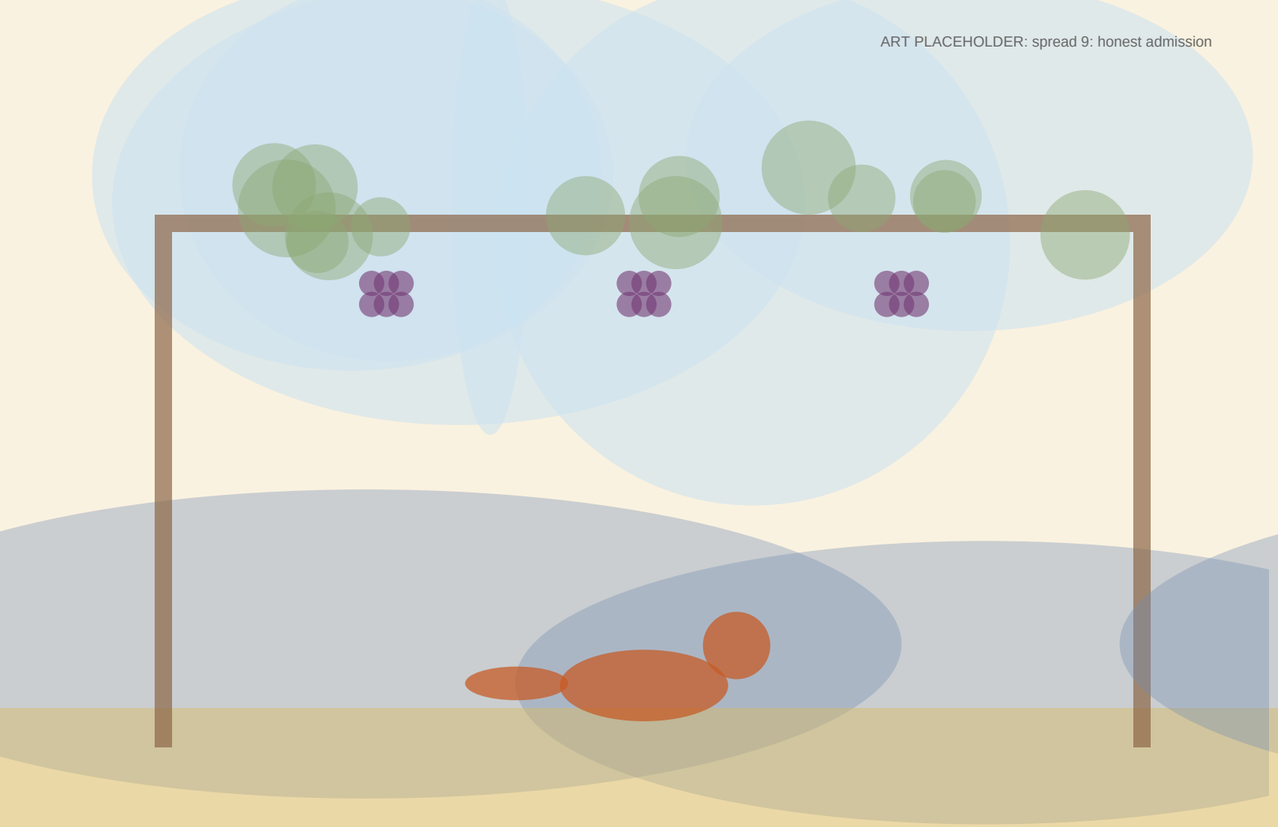
But after a few steps, Fern stopped.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 8: pause; backward glance



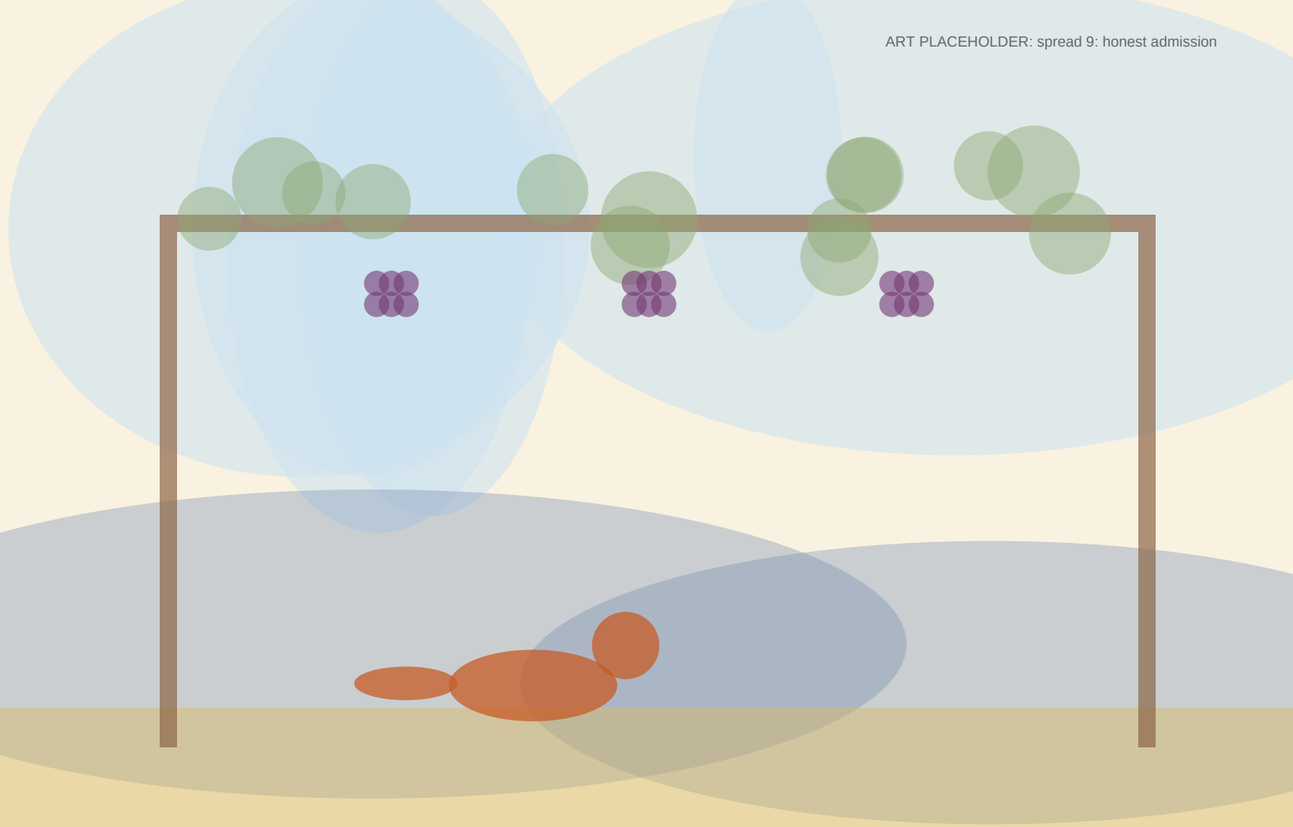
She had not tasted even one grape. How could she know?

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 9: honest admission



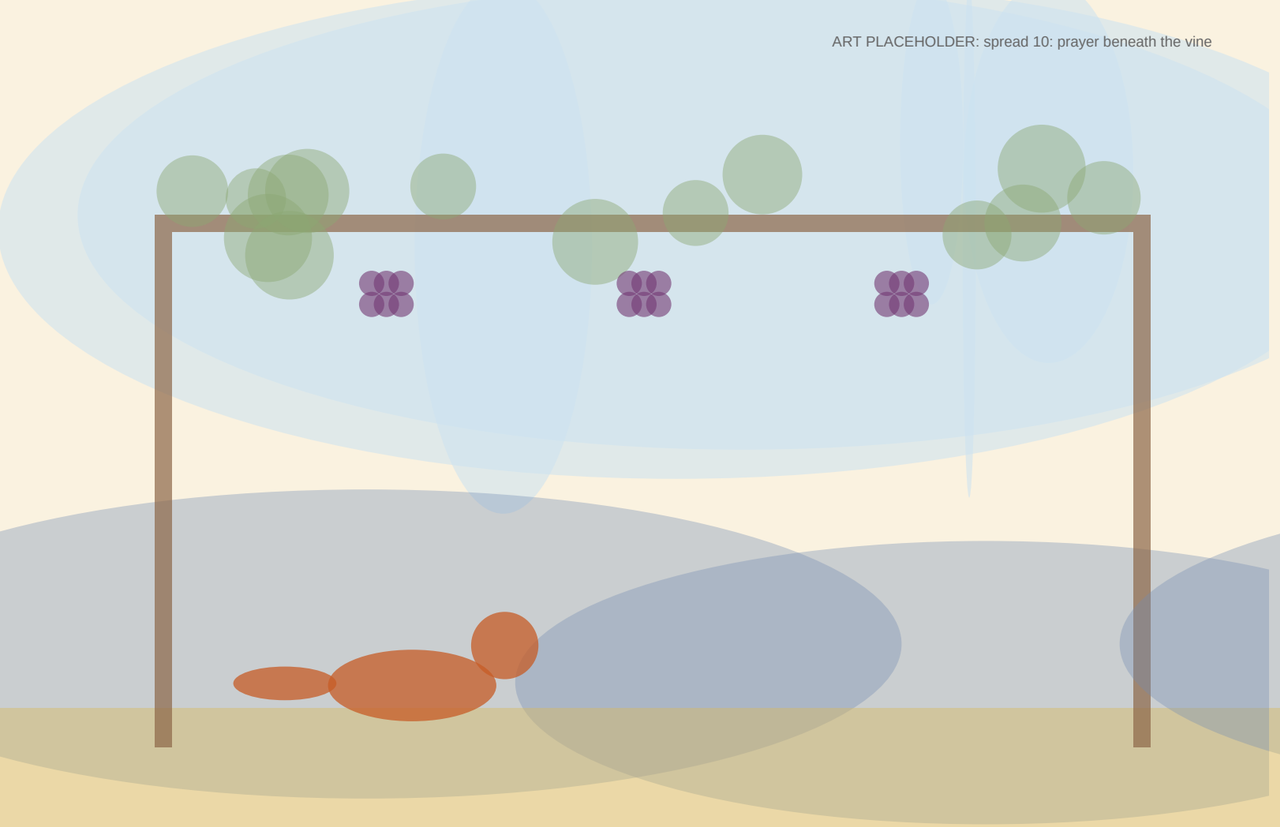
“I wanted them,” she admitted. “I’m upset because I can’t reach them.”

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 9: honest admission



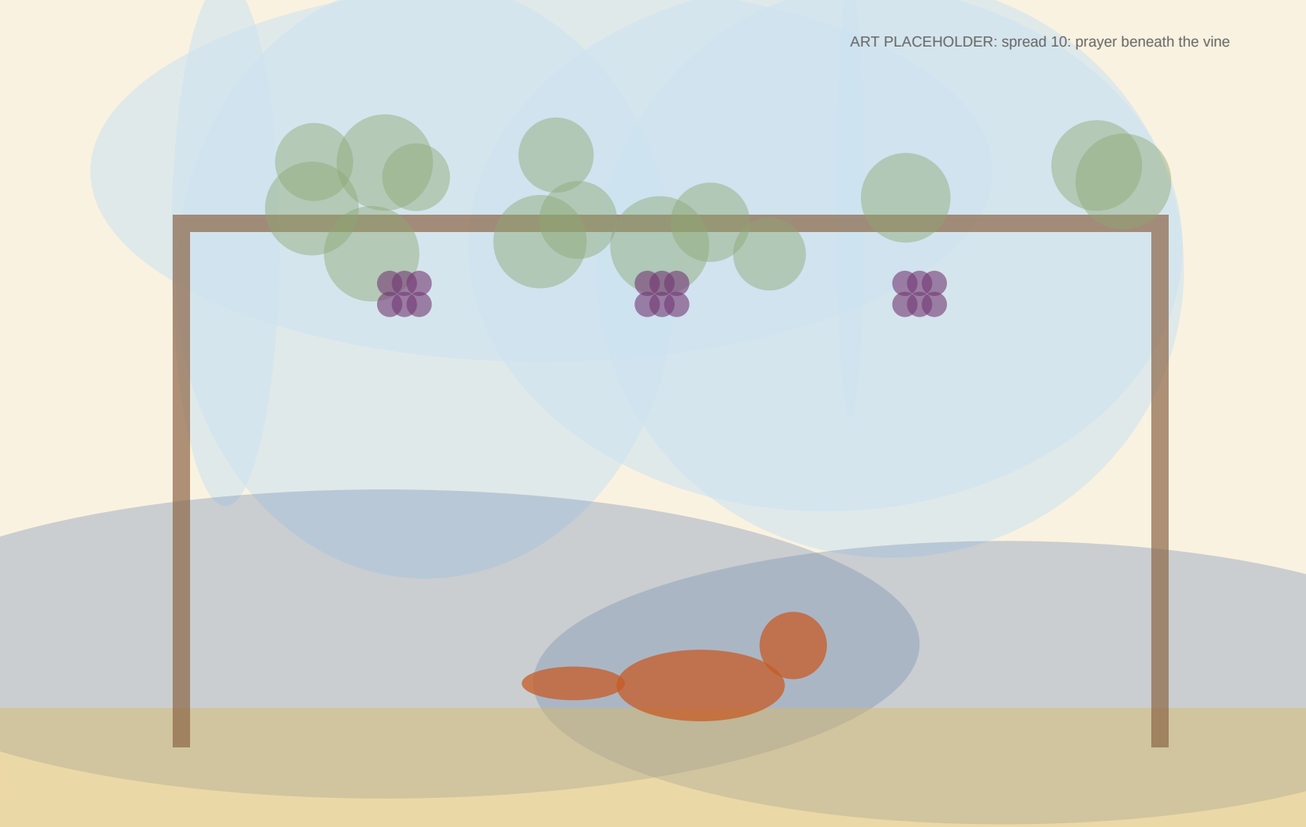
She let out a long, slow breath.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 10: prayer beneath the vine



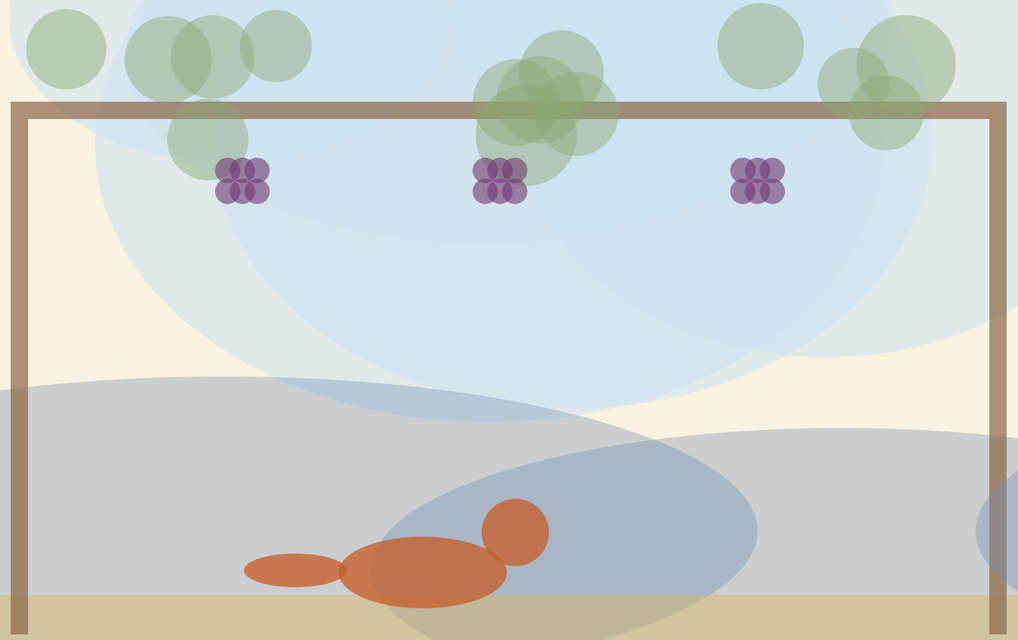
“God, please help me tell the truth and be thankful.”

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 10: prayer beneath the vine



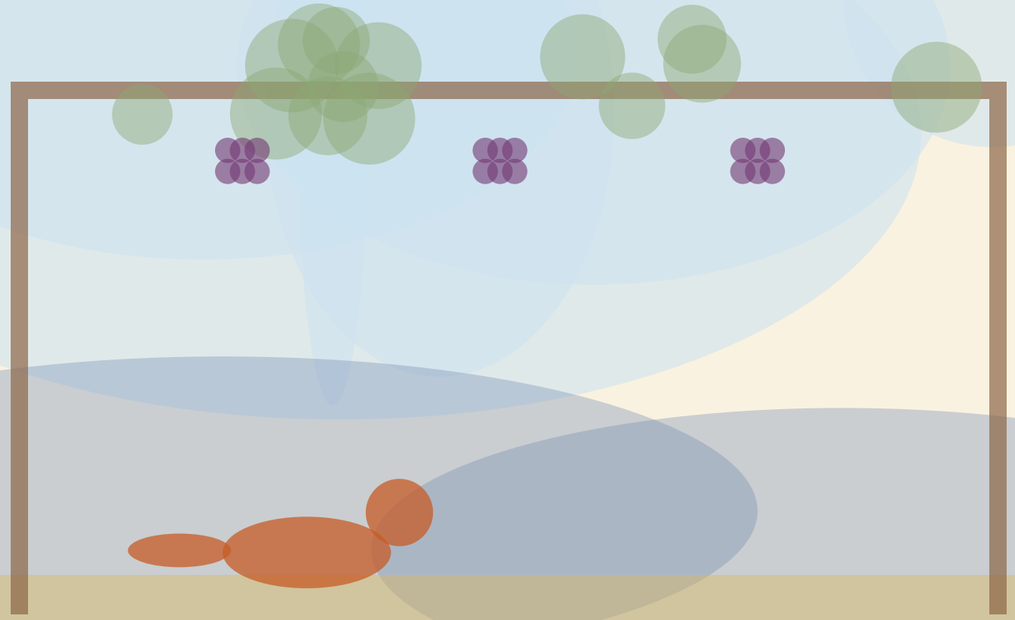
The grapes still hung high. Fern’s tummy still rumbled.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 11: calm look up



She could be disappointed without saying something unkind.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 11: calm look up

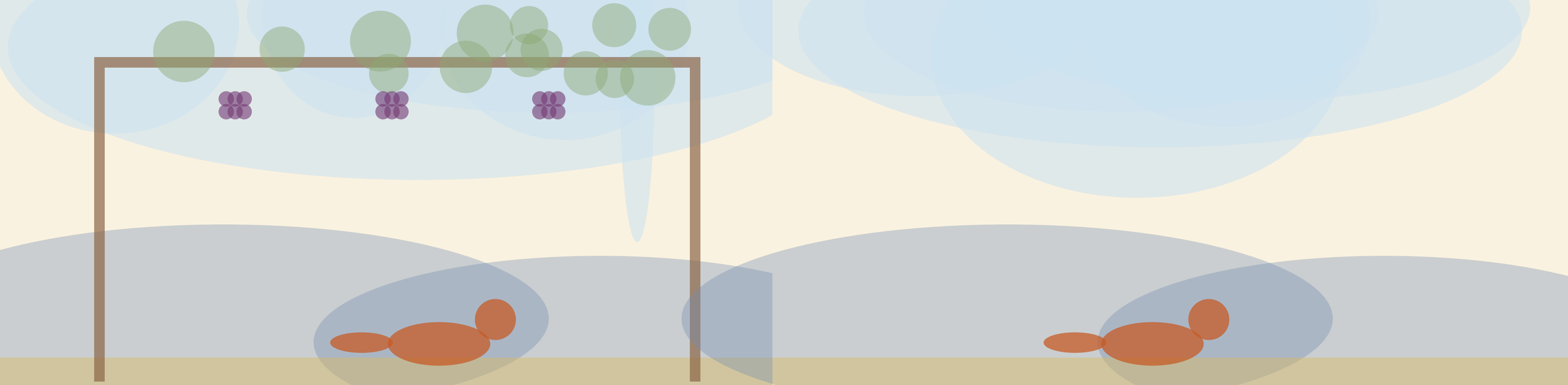


“You may be perfectly good grapes,” she said.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 12: toward the creek

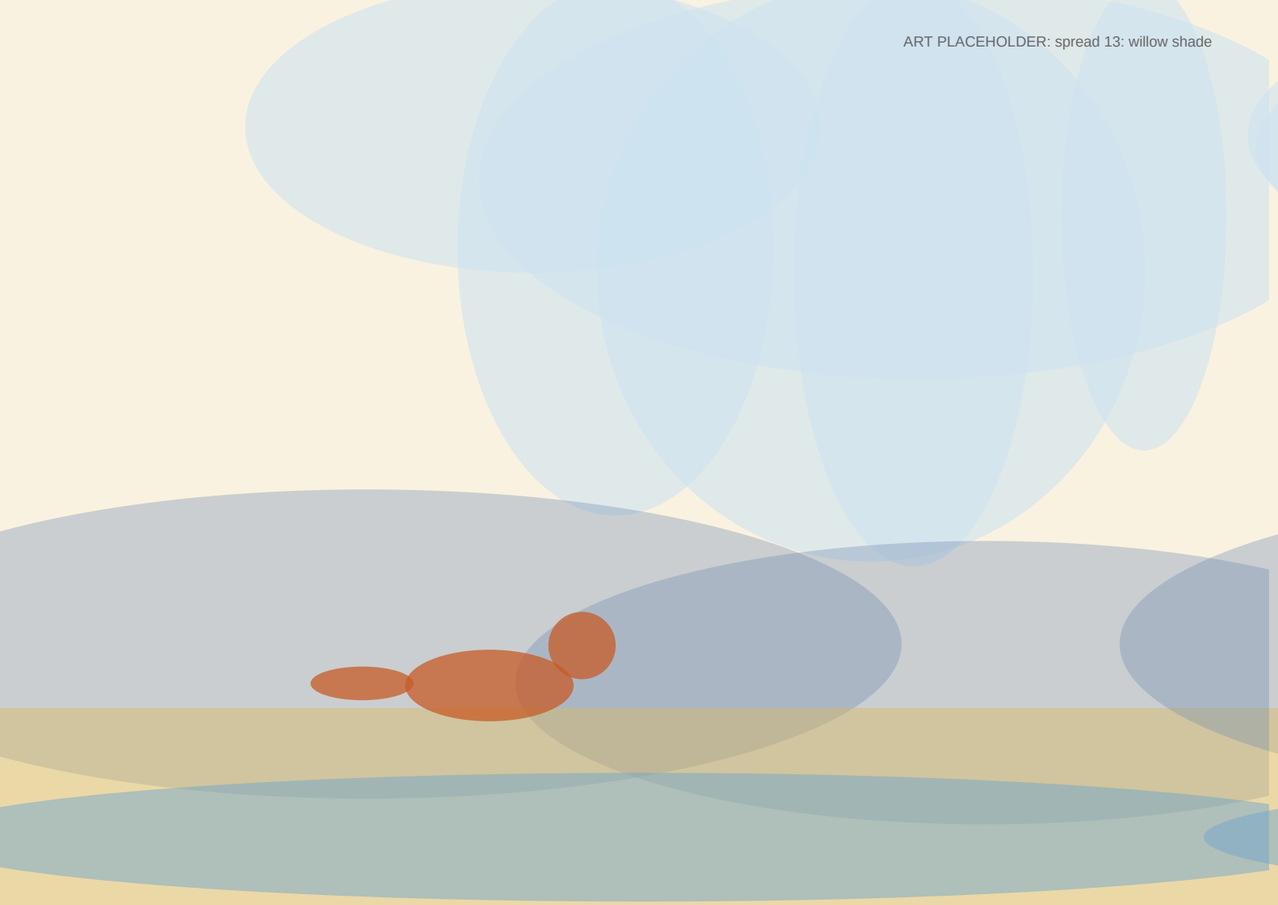
“I just can’t reach you today.”

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 12: toward the creek



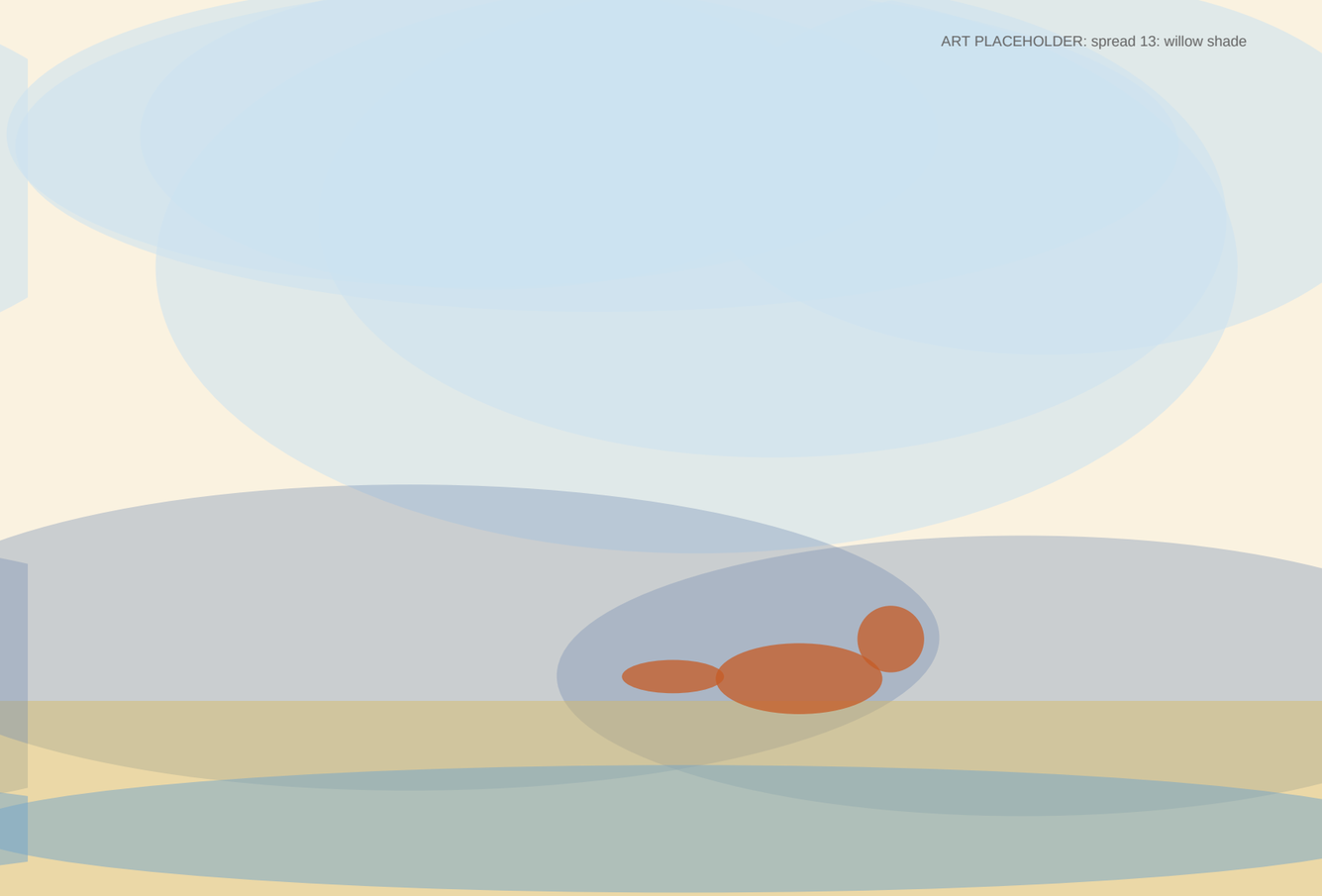
Fern padded to the shady creek and took a cool drink.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 13: willow shade



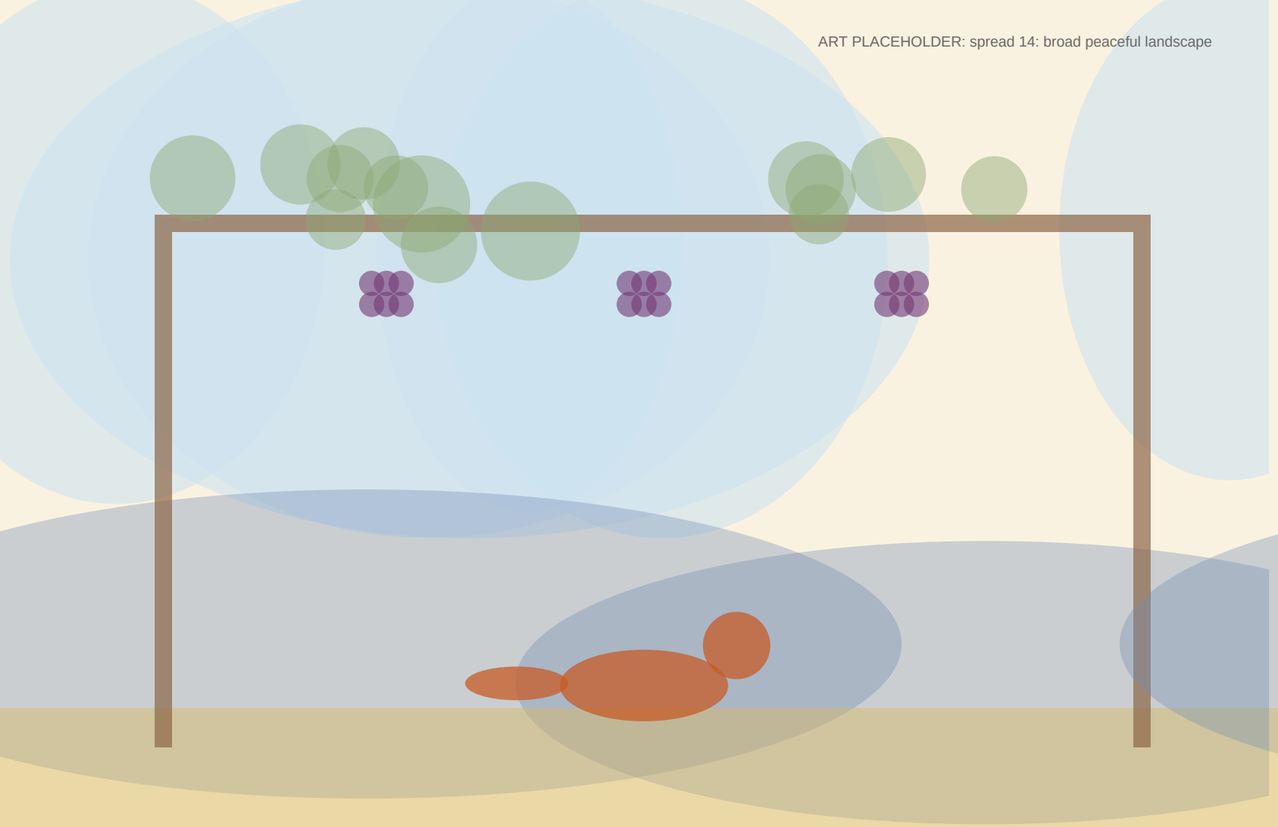
Then she rested her tired paws beneath a willow.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 13: willow shade



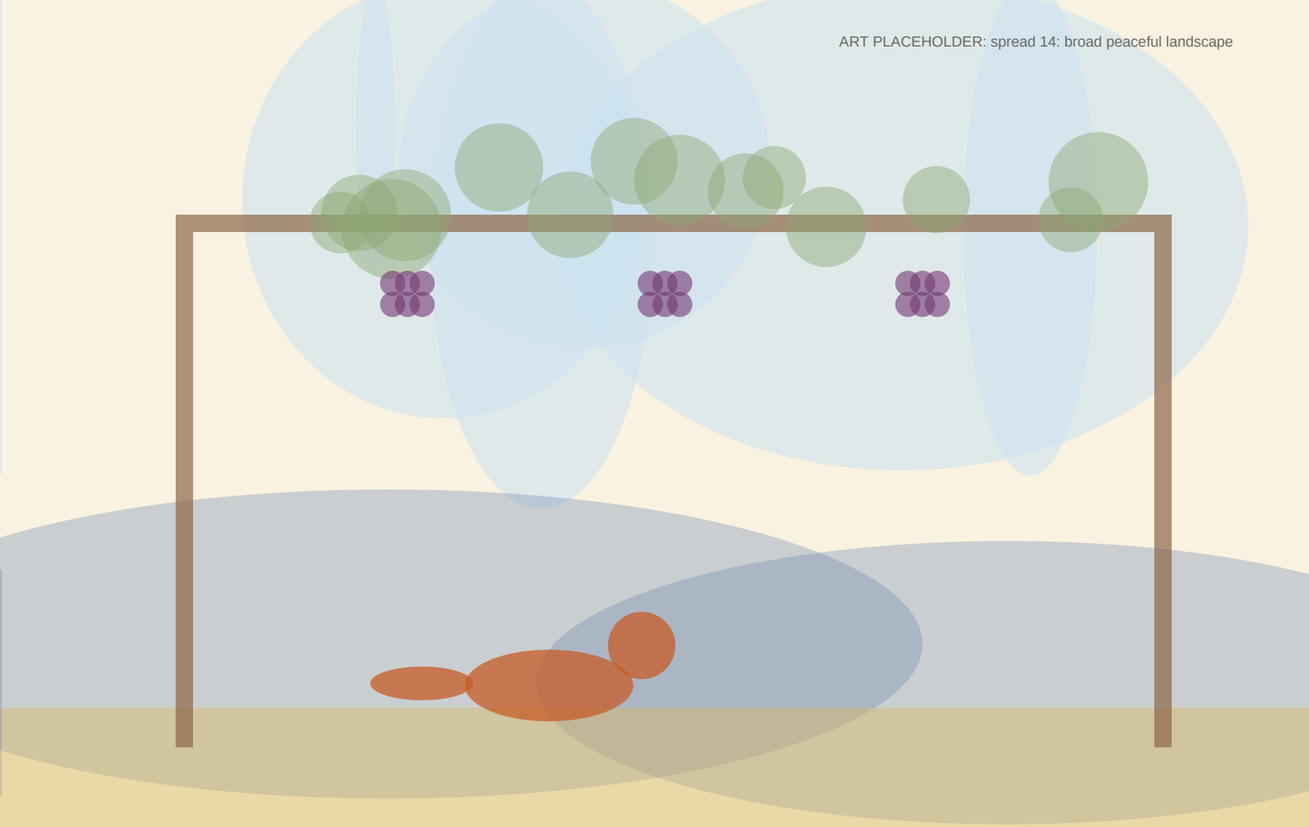
Soon she would look for supper. For now, she could leave the grapes in peace.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 14: broad peaceful landscape



When we cannot have something, calling it bad does not make us truthful.

ART PLACEHOLDER: spread 14: broad peaceful landscape



With God’s help, we can practice self-control and learn contentment.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law.

Galatians 5:22-23 (BSB)



I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances. I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. In any and every situation I have learned the secret of being filled and being hungry, of having plenty and having need.

Philippians 4:11-12 (BSB)



Source: "The Fox and the Grapes," The Fables of Phaedrus, Book IV, translated by Henry T. Riley and Christopher Smart (Project Gutenberg eBook #25512), archived at github.com/martyschoff/fables. This story is a NEW adaptation for young readers, not the words of Phaedrus, Riley, or Smart. Fern's pause, honest admission, prayer, and reconsideration are new material added in this adaptation. Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB). The BSB has been dedicated to the public domain.

